



international markets. Azulay added, “We are not here to profit from the startups. Our mission is to promote US’ best practices and support the entrepreneurial spirit of India”.

Azulay also clarified, “We are not here to compete with other incubators and co-working spaces. India’s entrepreneurship community is growing daily and there is room for all kinds of organizations; co-working spaces, e-cells, technology incubators, business incubators, and so on. Honestly, we hope that in 4-5 years the kind of incubation services we offer will be much more commonplace in India and the need for Nexus will not be so great”. Unlike other co-working spaces, startups don’t just get office space at Nexus. The startups also have at their disposal the expertise of Nexus’ international team from ACIR, the mentorship of industry leaders, and support of partner organisations such as FICCI, TiE, and IAN. In addition, Nexus also offers incubator management training to even support other incubator managers in India that need help creating holistic curricula, and understand how to run a successful incubator.

Nexus provides early-stage startups with something much more crucial than mere office space – access to a network of industry veterans and entrepreneurs that have already traversed the arduous journeys of setting up startups, therefore, they can offer practical support to the needy Indian startups. Azulay also believes, “The combination of workshops, practical lectures, hands-on mentoring and access to our networks, we feel, is unmatched in India”. Ayushi Mishra, co-founder, DronaMaps (Cohort 7), told Digit more about the startups’ experience at Nexus, “Nexus helped us regain perspective by guiding us on the operational minutiae, introducing us to a VC network, lawyers to consult on intellectual property etc. It is a very hands-on program that helps startups put a structure to their company with incisive insights from Eric Azulay, Vikas Sood, and Sameer Malik, all industry experts with years of experience of working in innovation”.

“

Considering the relatively short length of our program, and that Nexus does not invest in these early-stage startups and the early stage of development of our startups, the results we’ve seen are frankly astonishing and are to us a clear indication of the large impact a successful incubation program can have”.

–ERIK AZULAY, EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR, NEXUS

”

DRONAMAPS (COHORT 7)

Founded by Utkarsh Singh and Ayushi Mishra, DronaMaps is a startup that leverages imagery collected through drones to create large-scale 3D maps. Both founders are Forbes 30 under 30 (Asia) alumni as well. The 3D maps are created with aerial photogrammetry where a consumer-grade camera is mounted on a drone and this camera captures multiple images at different angles. DronaMaps bolsters image reconstruction algorithms with strategic sorting of images and merging of small maps, all aided by deep learning algorithms developed in-house. Ayushi Mishra says, “Photogrammetric reconstruction from imagery captured through satellite into maps, while ensuring the accuracy of the map, has existed under the discipline of geospatial intelligence. Drone-based mapping is an extension of this, which borrows from the broader discipline but builds on it, the swathes of areas captured in satellite imagery are huge, in the range of 200 sq/km and multiple points are matched, while in drone maps, more than thousands of points are matched, therefore, it is computationally more intense”.



She further elaborates, “At the end of the process, you are left with a gigantic image that needs to be mined for information. Our deep learning algorithms come into the picture at this point – to use the high-resolution

maps captured by drones and identify 14 geospatial features required for development planning”. Some of these geospatial features include the location of trees, plot boundaries, location of roads, utilities such as power lines, etc. The startup also stepped up during the Covid-19 pandemic and increased the types of data inputs their algorithm could accept to include the location of patients, quarantined individuals, hospitals, testing facilities, and others. They helped develop a central Covid-19 tracking dashboard for India as well. The founders realised that their technology was capable of providing solutions for emergent needs from contact tracing to healthcare infrastructure management. At present, DronaMaps’ coronavirus solution has been implemented in Rajasthan, Haryana, Punjab, and a few other places.